Web search, for free? Where does that get you?' Page explained that Google wasn't focused on search at all. 'We're really making an AI,' he said.[4] Having lots of data makes it easier to create an AI. And AI can turn lots of data into lots of power.

By the 2010s, the dream was becoming a reality. Like every major historical revolution, the rise of AI was a gradual process involving numerous steps. And like every revolution, a few of these steps were seen as turning points, just like the opening of the Liverpool–Manchester Railway. In the prolific literature on the story of AI, two events pop up again and again. The first occurred when, on 30 September 2012, a convolutional neural network called AlexNet won the ImageNet Large Scale Visual Recognition Challenge.

If you have no idea what a convolutional neural network is, and if you have never heard of the ImageNet challenge, you are not alone. More than 99 per cent of us are in the same situation, which is why AlexNet's victory was hardly front-page news in 2012. But some humans did hear about AlexNet's victory and decoded the writing on the wall.

They knew, for example, that ImageNet is a database of millions of annotated digital images. Did a website ever ask you to prove that you are not a robot by looking at a set of images and indicating which ones contain a car or a cat? The images you clicked were perhaps added to the ImageNet database. The same thing might also have happened to tagged images of your pet cat that you uploaded online. The ImageNet Large Scale Visual Recognition Challenge tests various algorithms on how well they are able to identify the annotated images in the database. Can they correctly identify the cats? When humans are asked to do it, out of one hundred cat images we correctly identify ninety-five as cats. In 2010 the best algorithms had a success rate of only 72 per cent. In 2011 the algorithmic success rate crawled up to 75 per cent. In 2012 the AlexNet algorithm won the challenge and stunned the still minuscule community of AI experts by achieving a success rate of 85 per cent. While this improvement may not sound like much to laypersons, it demonstrated to the experts the potential for rapid progress in certain AI domains. By 2015 a Microsoft algorithm achieved 96 per cent accuracy, surpassing the human ability to identify cat images.

In 2016, *The Economist* published a piece titled 'From Not Working to Neural Networking' that asked, 'How has artificial intelligence, associated with hubris and disappointment since its earliest days, suddenly become the